

BATTLE OF THE BOTS

THE FUTURE OF WARFARE

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Fully autonomous weapons systems remove humans from the loop of the decision-making process, when it comes to using lethal force against other humans. Already around the world, there are weaponised machines that can be operated remotely, and defence contractors are researching heavily into the use of artificial intelligence in future weaponised platforms. Apart from algorithmic bias, a lack of accountability when things go wrong, and the ethical concerns over a lack of human agency, one of the major concerns is that the world powers can go into a robotics arms race, where it is easier to go into war, and countries become more adventurous. The concerns are particularly heightened because of the nature of the long lasting asymmetric wars in modern times, where psychological, political and institutional pressures are used along with conventional approaches. A number of AI experts including Stephen Hawking, Elon Musk and Demis Hassabis signed a letter warning of an AI arms race. Subsequently, a number of organisations including Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch have called for an international treaty on the ban of killer robots, under the aegis of Convention on Conventional Weapons (CCW), which would prevent countries from building and deploying these machines in the first place. However a number of world powers including UK, US, Russia, China and Israel are opposed to the treaty and continue to develop these platforms. More details about this initiative can be found at <https://www.stopkillerrobots.org>. In this cover story, we will have a closer look at exactly what these machines are and what they are capable of.

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